

« BEFORE

The assassinations of South Vietnam's President Diem and President Kennedy three weeks later changed the situation in Vietnam and the US response to it.

MILITARY JUNTA

The increasingly repressive regime of President Diem, culminating in the **Buddhist crisis** through the summer and fall of 1963, led Kennedy and his advisers to back **a coup d'état in South Vietnam**, during which **Diem was assassinated**. He was replaced by a **military junta**.

NEW PRESIDENT

Lyndon Johnson, who became president following **Kennedy's assassination** in November 1963, was a hardliner. He and his advisers expected that Diem's removal would dramatically improve the situation in South Vietnam, but this proved to be misguided.



US VICE PRESIDENT LYNDON B. JOHNSON IS SWORN IN AS PRESIDENT

While President Johnson was busy reaffirming US commitments to South Vietnam, the news from the country kept getting worse. In the view of US Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara, the 12 army officers who formed the Military Revolutionary Council governing the country were so preoccupied with political affairs that they were failing to give their troops or government officials outside Saigon any direction. Nor were they supported by the various other factions who had opposed Diem.

The key question for President Johnson was not whether, but how, to prop up South Vietnam. Although opinion polls showed him to have a huge lead over Senator Barry Goldwater, his chief Republican challenger in the 1964 election, Johnson worried about his prospects. At a White House reception on Christmas Eve 1963, he told the Joint Chiefs of Staff: "Just let me get elected and then you can have your war."